

Exp 2: Setting up a Zoho Creator account and exploring the platform architecture and interface

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1. Introduction

Low-code application development platforms have transformed the way organizations design, build, and deploy business software by minimizing the amount of hand-written code required. Zoho Creator is one such cloud-based low-code platform developed by Zoho Corporation that enables users to design custom applications for business needs such as education management, inventory tracking, CRM, and workflow automation without extensive programming expertise. This report documents a hands-on exercise of creating a Zoho Creator account, exploring its console, and studying the underlying architecture that supports application development, deployment, and management.

The exercise was carried out by creating a fresh organization account on the Zoho Creator platform and navigating through its major modules, namely Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing. Each of these modules represents a distinct functional layer of the platform and collectively they illustrate how a modern Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) low-code platform is structured.

2. Objective of the Study

- To create and configure a new account on the Zoho Creator platform.
- To explore the primary navigation structure of the Creator console, including the Develop, Deploy, and Manage sections.
- To understand the purpose and functionality of each module available to a Super Admin user.
- To document the platform's architecture through a layered architecture diagram.
- To relate the observed interface elements to core management and information-systems concepts such as role-based access control, multi-stage deployment, and governance.

3. Overview of Zoho Creator

Zoho Creator is a cloud-based, low-code application development platform that allows individuals and organizations to build custom web and mobile applications rapidly using drag-and-drop form builders, visual workflow designers, and a proprietary scripting language called Deluge (Data Enriched Language for the Universal Grid Environment). It is part of the larger Zoho suite of business productivity applications and is positioned as a tool for citizen developers as well as professional programmers.

The platform is organized broadly into three functional groups that are visible in the left-hand navigation panel of the console: DEVELOP (Applications and Microservices), DEPLOY (Environments, Mobile, and Portal), and MANAGE (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and

Billing). This grouping reflects the typical lifecycle of a business application — from design and development, through staged deployment, to ongoing administration and governance.

4. Account Setup and Platform Walkthrough

4.1 Application Dashboard

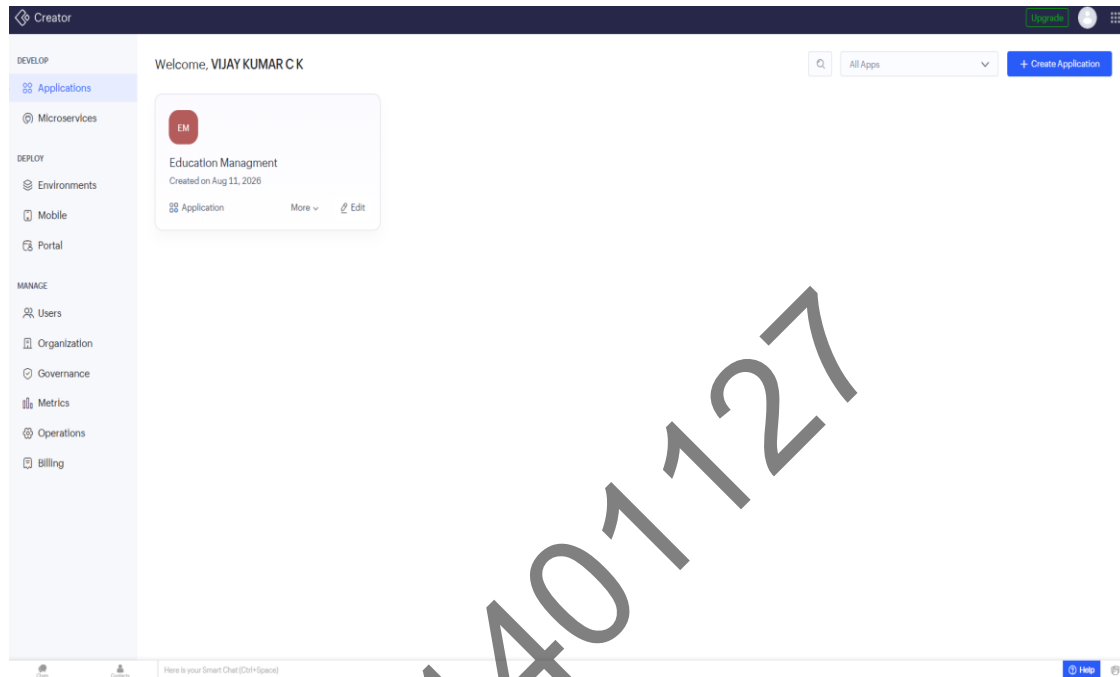


Figure 4.1: Applications dashboard showing the newly created 'Education Management' application.

After successfully signing in with the account `vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs@rajalakshmi.edu.in`, the landing page of Zoho Creator displays a personalized welcome message, 'Welcome, VIJAY KUMAR C K', confirming that the account was created successfully. The main panel lists all applications owned by the user; here it shows a single application named 'Education Management', created on 11 August 2026, represented by an auto-generated 'EM' icon. Options such as Application, More, and Edit allow the user to open, configure, or modify the application. The top-right corner provides a search bar, an 'All Apps' filter, and a prominent 'Create Application' button, which is the primary entry point for building a new low-code application from scratch or from a template.

4.2 Microservices Module

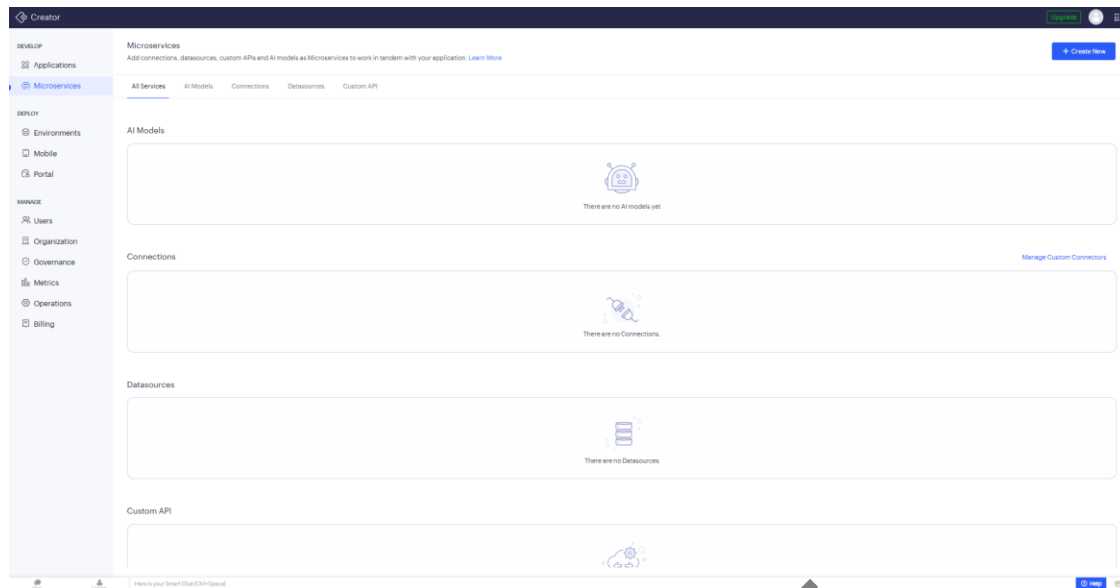


Figure 4.2: Microservices module listing AI Models, Connections, Datasources, and Custom API categories.

The Microservices section allows an application to be extended using modular, reusable services. This screen is divided into four sub-tabs — AI Models, Connections, Datasources, and Custom API — each of which is currently empty for the new account, as indicated by placeholder illustrations and messages such as 'There are no AI models yet' and 'There are no Connections.' Conceptually, AI Models would allow integration of machine-learning capabilities into an application; Connections allow linking to third-party services (for example, payment gateways or Google services); Datasources allow the application to read from or write to external databases; and Custom API allows exposing or consuming REST-based application programming interfaces. This module demonstrates the platform's service-oriented architecture, where core application logic can be decoupled from auxiliary services.

4.3 Environments (Deployment Space)

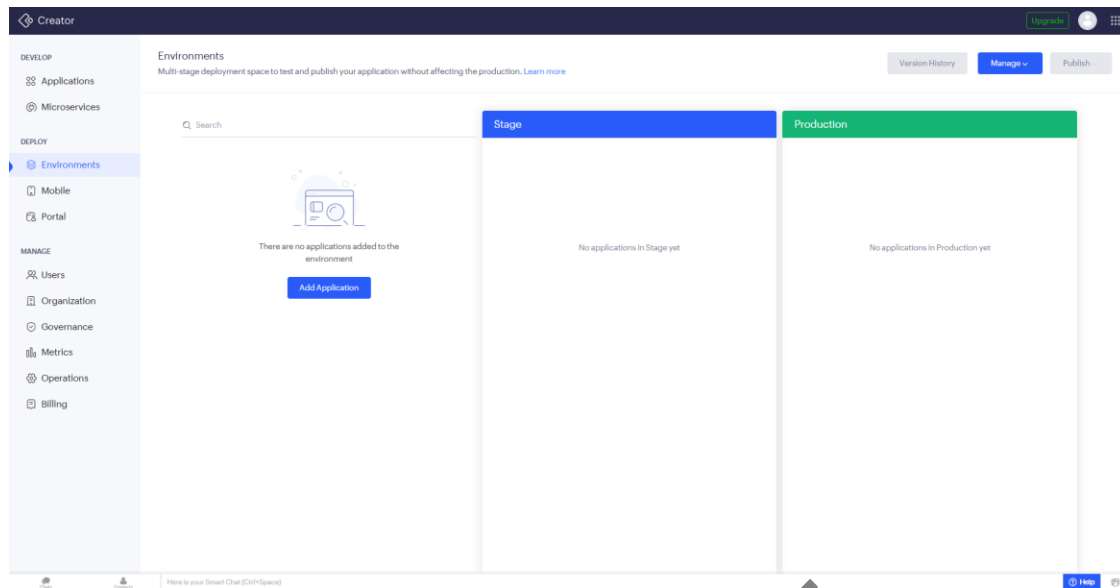


Figure 4.3: Environments screen showing the Stage and Production deployment spaces.

The Environments page implements a multi-stage deployment model consisting of a 'Stage' environment (shown in blue) and a 'Production' environment (shown in green). Because no application has yet been added to either space, both columns display 'No applications in Stage yet' and 'No applications in Production yet' respectively, along with an 'Add Application' button. This separation between staging and production mirrors standard software-engineering practice, allowing developers to test an application safely before it is published for end users. The top toolbar additionally provides 'Version History', 'Manage', and 'Publish' controls for governing the release process.

4.4 Mobile Application Distribution

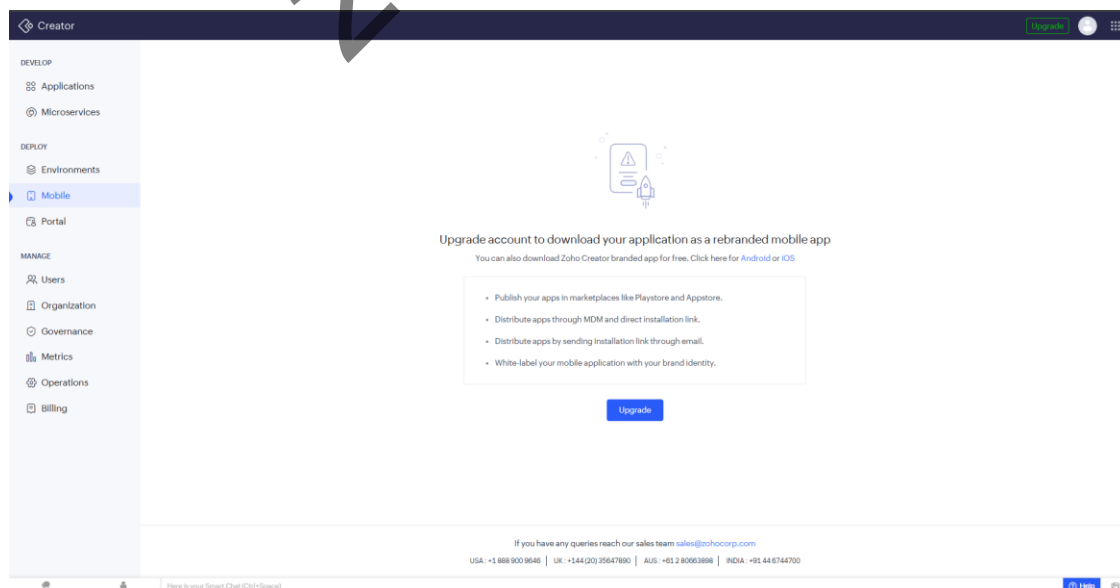


Figure 4.4: Mobile module prompting an account upgrade to enable rebranded mobile app distribution.

The Mobile section is designed to let organizations package their Creator applications as native, white-labelled mobile apps for the Play Store and App Store. Since the account is on the free plan, the console displays an upgrade prompt explaining the benefits of this feature: publishing to app marketplaces, distributing through Mobile Device Management (MDM) or direct installation links, and fully white-labelling the app with the organization's own brand identity. A free, Zoho-branded alternative app for Android and iOS is also offered as a link for users who do not wish to upgrade.

4.5 Portal Configuration

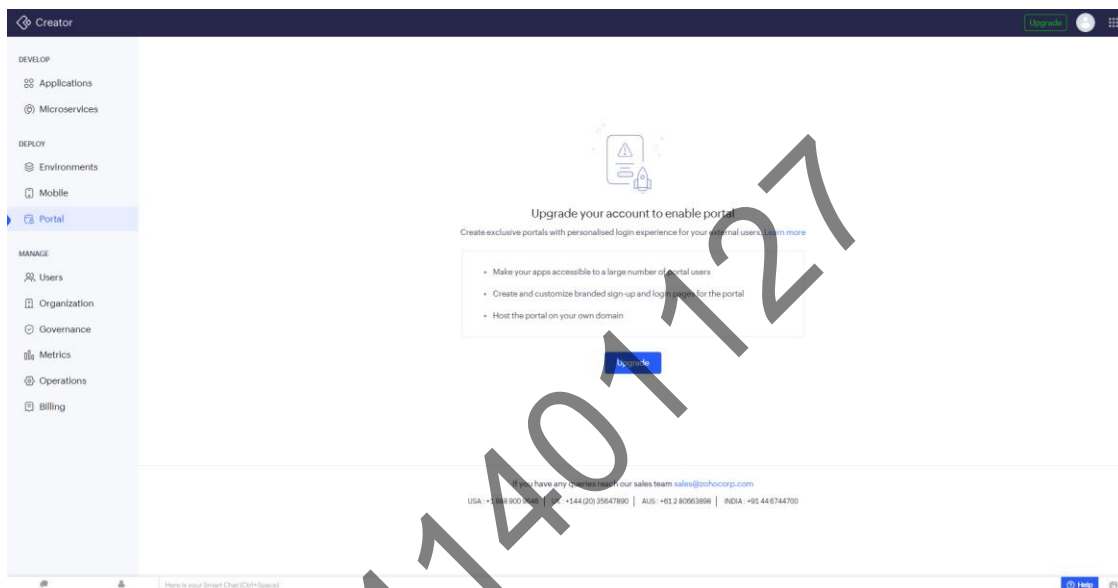


Figure 4.5: Portal module requiring an account upgrade to enable an external-user portal.

Similar to the Mobile module, the Portal feature is gated behind a paid plan. A Portal in Zoho Creator is a dedicated, branded access point through which external users (for example, students or parents in an education-management application) can log in and interact with select parts of the application without being counted as internal developers or administrators. The screen lists the key advantages of enabling a portal: making applications accessible to a large number of external users, customizing branded sign-up and login pages, and hosting the portal on the organization's own domain.

4.6 User Management

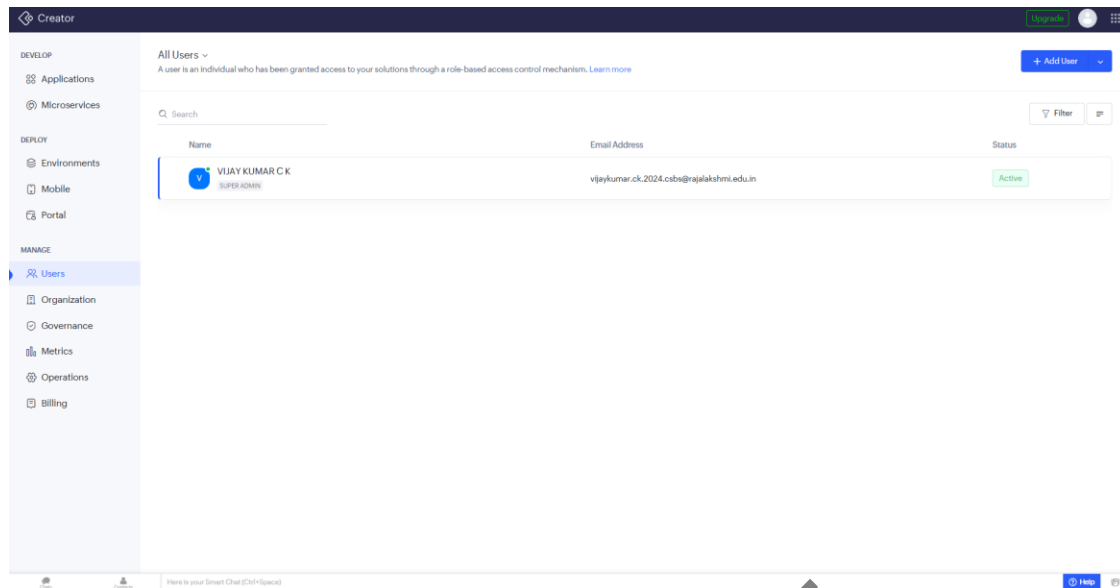


Figure 4.6: All Users screen listing the account owner with the Super Admin role.

The Users page under the MANAGE section displays every individual who has been granted access to the organization's applications through role-based access control. At this stage, only one user is listed — VIJAY KUMAR C K — holding the role of SUPER ADMIN, with the registered email vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs@rajalakshmi.edu.in and an 'Active' status. The interface provides an 'Add User' button to invite additional users, along with search and filter tools. This screen exemplifies the identity-and-access-management (IAM) principle by which permissions are assigned to named roles rather than to individuals directly.

4.7 Organization Settings

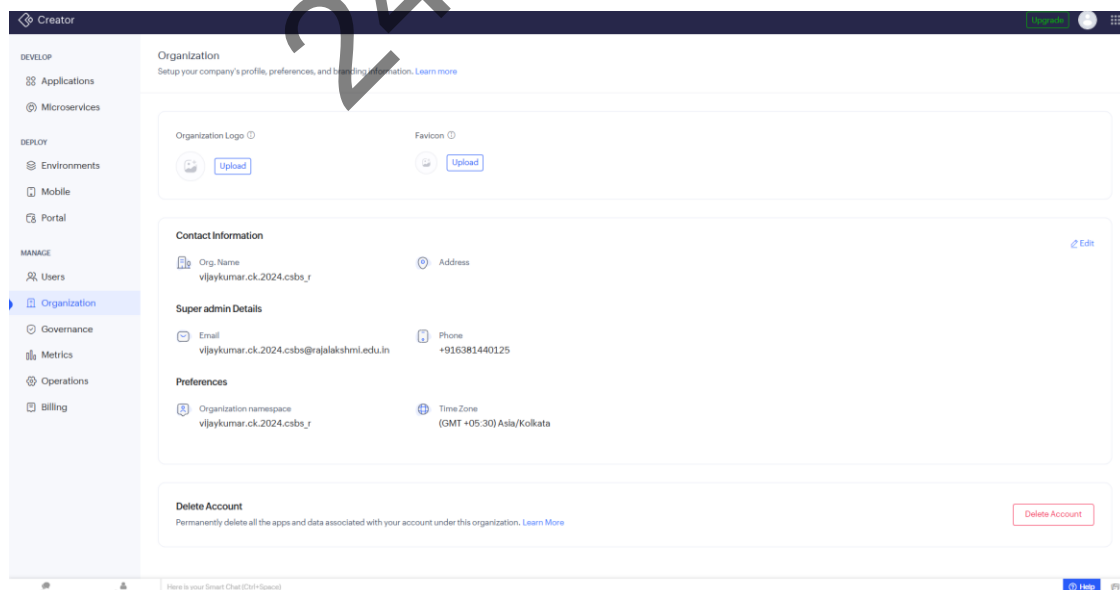


Figure 4.7: Organization settings displaying company profile, super-admin details, and preferences.

The Organization page consolidates the account's identity information. It is divided into three parts: (i) branding options to upload an Organization Logo and Favicon; (ii) Contact Information, which records the organization name (vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs_r) and address; and (iii) Super Admin Details and Preferences, showing the registered email, phone number, organization namespace, and time zone, set here to (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata. A 'Delete Account' option is also provided at the bottom for permanently removing all applications and data associated with the organization, reflecting good practice in providing users full control (and reversibility) over their data.

4.8 Governance and Security Policies

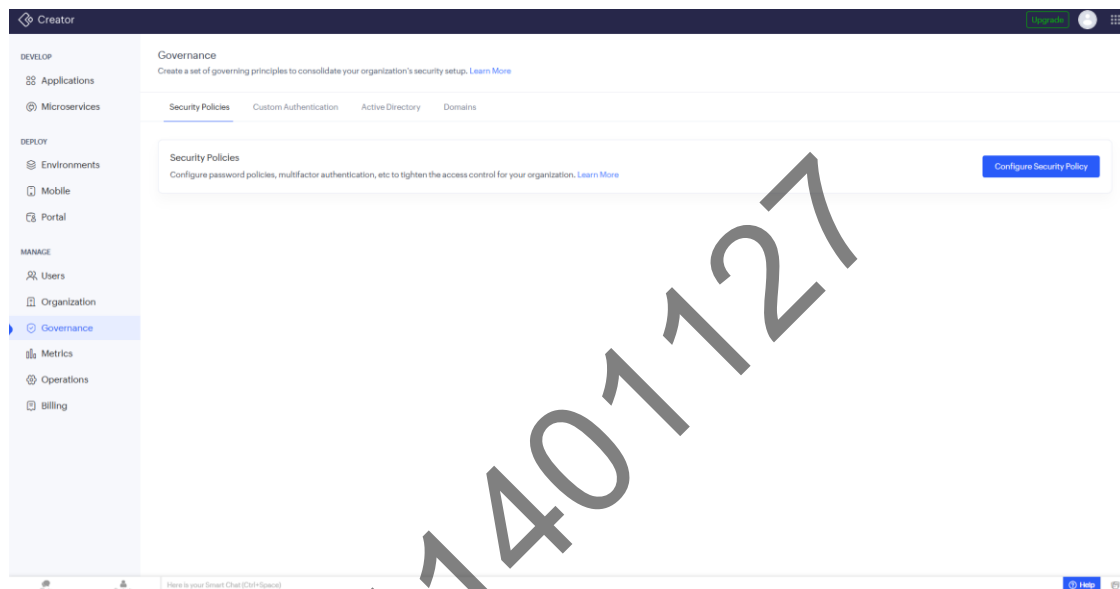


Figure 4.8: Governance module with Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains tabs.

The Governance section is where an organization consolidates its security posture. Four tabs are visible: Security Policies, Custom Authentication, Active Directory, and Domains. The Security Policies tab, shown active, allows configuration of password policies and multi-factor authentication (MFA) to tighten access control across the organization through a 'Configure Security Policy' button. Custom Authentication would allow integrating third-party identity providers, Active Directory enables enterprise directory-service synchronisation, and Domains allows restricting access to specific verified email domains — all of which are standard enterprise governance controls found in mature SaaS platforms.

4.9 Metrics and Analytics

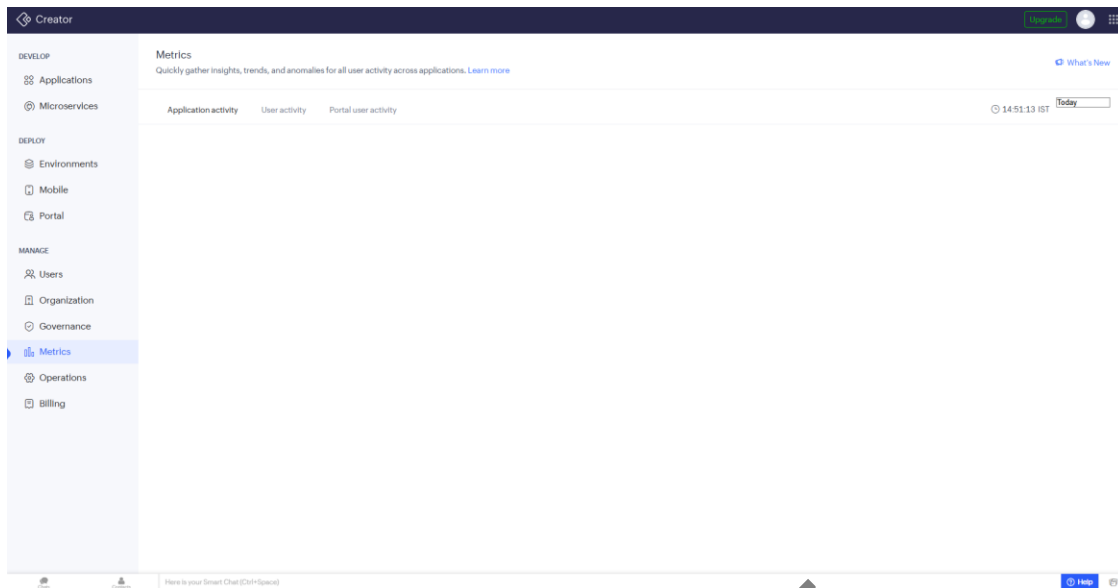


Figure 4.9: Metrics dashboard for tracking application and user activity.

The Metrics page is intended to give administrators insight into how applications and users behave over time. It offers three views — Application Activity, User Activity, and Portal User Activity — along with a live clock (shown here as 14:51:13 IST) and a date-range filter currently set to 'Today'. As no application traffic has yet been generated, the activity panel is empty, but in an active deployment this dashboard would surface usage trends and anomalies, supporting data-driven administrative decision-making.

4.10 Operations Console

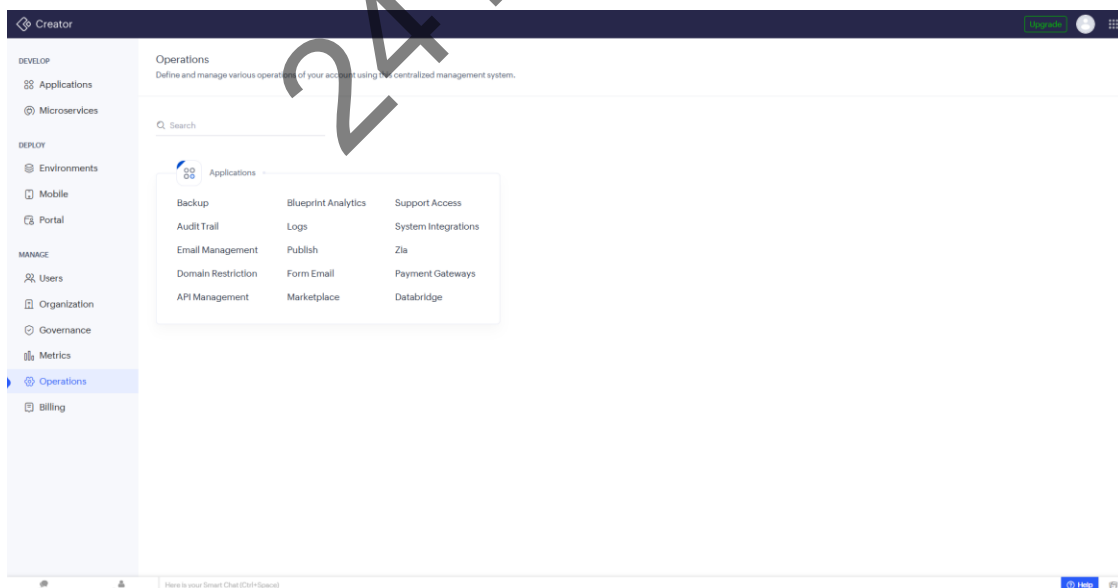


Figure 4.10: Operations console listing centralized administrative tools under the Applications category.

The Operations page acts as a centralized control panel for account-wide administrative tasks. Under the 'Applications' category it lists tools such as Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, Marketplace, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia (Zoho's AI assistant), Payment Gateways, and Databridge. Together these tools cover data protection (backup, audit trail), extensibility (API management, marketplace, integrations), communication (email management, form email), and monitoring (logs), reflecting the breadth of operational control given to a Super Admin.

4.11 Billing and Subscription

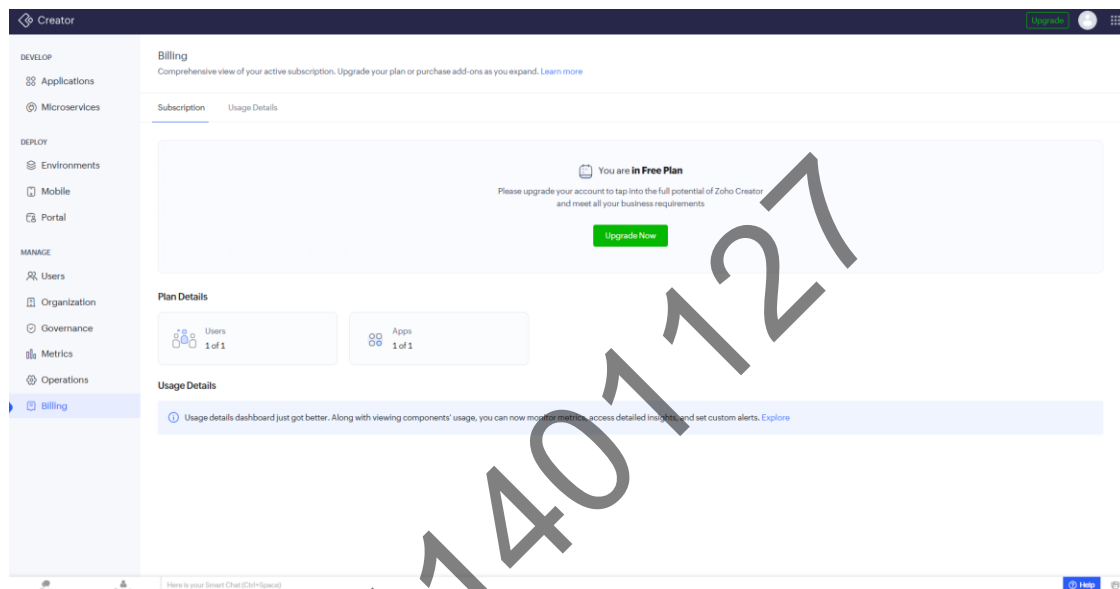


Figure 4.11: Billing page showing the account's Free Plan status and usage limits.

The Billing page confirms that the newly created account is on the 'Free Plan' and prompts the user to 'Upgrade Now' to access the platform's full capabilities. The Plan Details panel shows the current usage against plan limits — 1 of 1 Users and 1 of 1 Apps — meaning the free plan permits exactly one user and one application, which explains why the Mobile and Portal modules required an upgrade. A separate 'Usage Details' tab is available for monitoring component-level usage, insights, and custom alerts.

5. Platform Architecture

Based on the navigation structure explored above, the Zoho Creator platform can be represented as a five-layer architecture, moving from the end-user access points down to the underlying cloud infrastructure. The diagram below (Figure 5.1) summarizes this layered architecture as inferred from the console's own organization of features.

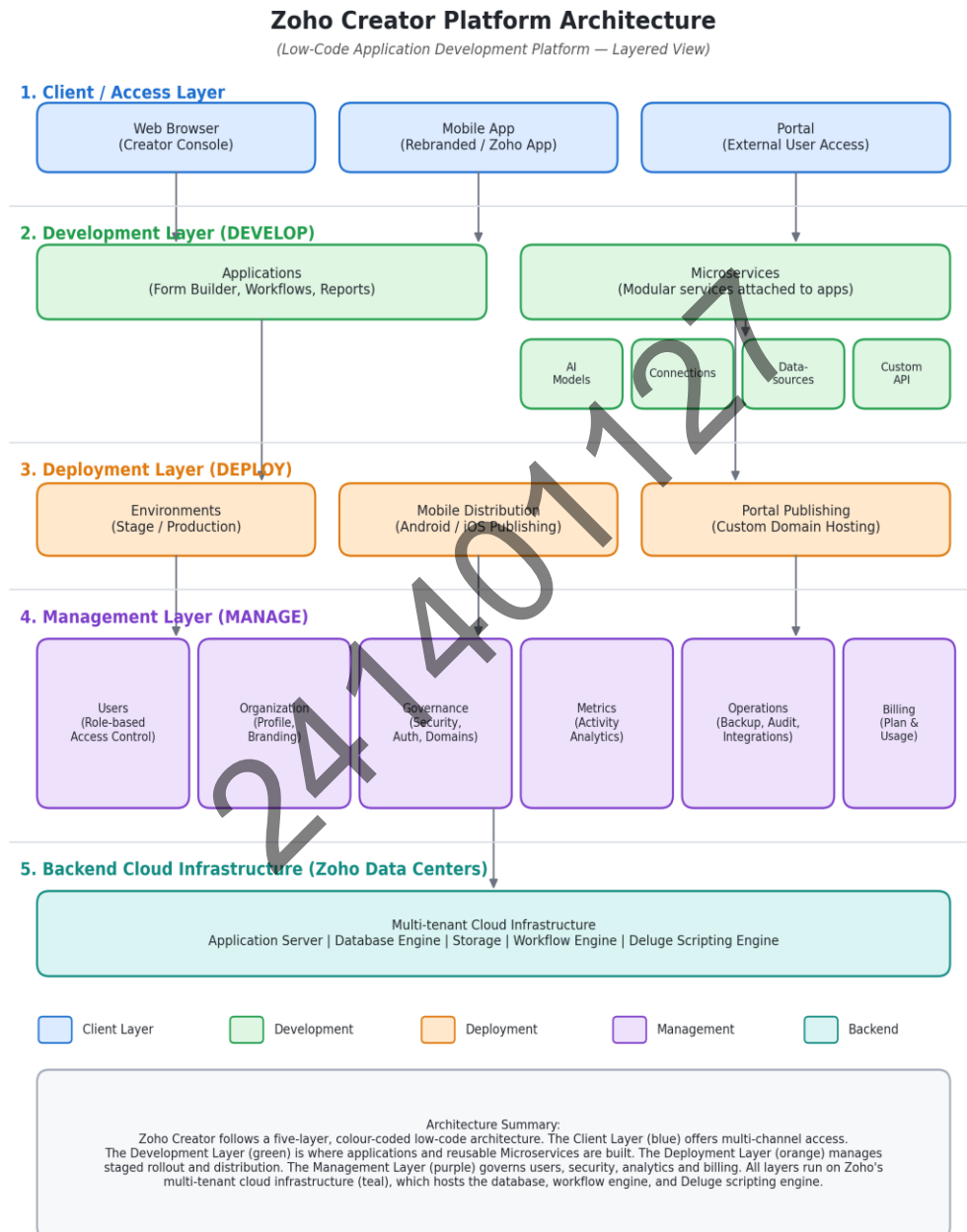


Figure 5.1: Layered architecture of the Zoho Creator platform.

5.1 Explanation of Architectural Layers

Layer 1 — Client / Access Layer: This is the outermost layer through which different classes of users reach the platform. It includes the Creator Console accessed via a web browser (used by developers and administrators), a rebranded or Zoho-branded Mobile App (used by end users on the go), and a Portal (used by external stakeholders such as students, customers, or vendors who need limited, branded access).

Layer 2 — Development Layer (DEVELOP): This layer contains the actual application-building tools. The 'Applications' module is the core low-code builder, where forms, pages, workflows, and reports are designed. The 'Microservices' module supplements applications with modular, reusable services — AI Models for intelligent features, Connections to third-party systems, Datasources for external data integration, and Custom APIs for exposing or consuming web services. This separation follows the principle of loose coupling, where core application logic and auxiliary services can evolve independently.

Layer 3 — Deployment Layer (DEPLOY): Once an application is built, it moves into this layer for controlled release. The 'Environments' module enforces a Stage-then-Production workflow, common in DevOps practice, to reduce the risk of deploying untested changes. 'Mobile Distribution' and 'Portal Publishing' extend the same application to native mobile channels and to external, custom-domain-hosted portals respectively.

Layer 4 — Management Layer (MANAGE): This layer provides administrative oversight across every application in the organization. 'Users' implements role-based access control; 'Organization' stores company-wide branding and preference data; 'Governance' enforces security policies, authentication rules, and domain restrictions; 'Metrics' offers analytics on application and user activity; 'Operations' bundles operational tools such as backup, audit trail, and integrations; and 'Billing' tracks subscription plans and resource usage limits.

Layer 5 — Backend Cloud Infrastructure: All the layers above are ultimately powered by Zoho's multi-tenant cloud infrastructure, comprising application servers, a database engine, storage, a workflow engine, and the Deluge scripting engine that executes custom business logic. Although this layer is not directly visible in the console, its presence is implied by every action performed in the higher layers — for instance, creating an application allocates storage and compute resources in this backend layer.

6. Observations and Learning Outcomes

- The Zoho Creator free plan is deliberately limited to one user and one application, which is sufficient for learning and prototyping but not for production use — a common freemium software-as-a-service (SaaS) strategy.
- The platform's navigation is organized around the natural lifecycle of an application: Develop, Deploy, and Manage, which mirrors standard software-engineering and IT-service-management practice.
- Features such as Governance, Metrics, and Operations demonstrate that a modern low-code platform is not just a development tool but also an enterprise administration suite.
- Several advanced features (Mobile rebranding, Portal, custom domains) are monetized as premium upgrades, illustrating a tiered pricing model typical of cloud software vendors.
- The separation of Stage and Production environments reinforces the management principle of controlled change, minimizing the risk of business disruption from untested releases.

7. Conclusion

This exercise of creating an account and navigating the Zoho Creator console provided practical insight into how a modern low-code, cloud-based application development platform is structured and administered. By walking through the Applications, Microservices, Environments, Mobile, Portal, Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, and Billing modules, it became evident that Zoho Creator organizes its functionality into clear development, deployment, and management stages, all supported by a common multi-tenant cloud backend. Such platforms significantly lower the barrier to building business applications, while still incorporating enterprise-grade concerns such as role-based access control, staged deployment, governance, and usage-based billing. Studying this interface offers useful, transferable understanding of SaaS platform design and of core management concepts such as access control, resource governance, and lifecycle management.

References

1. Zoho Corporation, "Zoho Creator Documentation," available at the official Zoho Creator help portal.
2. Screenshots captured directly from the author's own Zoho Creator account (Organization: vijaykumar.ck.2024.csbs_r) on 11 August 2026.